Hacktoberfest 2026 Abandons Pull-Request Rewards

A polished research synthesis of the incentive, maintainer, sponsor, accessibility, and governance implications of the 2026 Hacktoberfest pivot.

Source base: 10 parallel research agents, 31,000+ words of notes, plus an earlier 2026 report.

Key metrics

Metric	Value
Event window	October 2026
PRs / MRs count toward rewards	**No**
In-person Fests	300+ across 60+ countries
MLH events API (mid-Oct)	**531 across 71 countries**
Open hacktoberfest issues	669,307
Unclaimed issues	**~517,632 (derived)**
Repositories with topic	148,820
Repositories with accepted label	**25,097**
Online sticker thresholds	3 / 10 / 15 (or 17)
T-shirt promise	**Not promised online**

Participation and backlog visual snapshot

Values are drawn from official/API and aggregator sources cited in the report.

Registered participants

Eligible October PRs

October 2026 issues

Model shift

2020-2025 accounting model
- Counted pull requests
- 4 then 6 PR thresholds
- T-shirt or cap rewards
- Maintainer verification burden

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2026 participation model
- In-person Fests
- Judged AI challenges
- Sticker engagement economy
- Claimed issue work

October 2026 timeline

Window	Activity
Oct 1-4	DEV Weekend Challenge (deadline Oct 4, 11:59 PM PDT)
Oct 5-11	**DEV Week 1; theme ecosystem weeks follow**
Oct 9-15	Global Hack Week: Hacktoberfest
Oct 12-18	**DEV Week 2**
Mid-Oct	MLH API: 531 Fests / 71 countries; 669,307 open issues
Oct 19-25	**DEV Week 3**
Oct 26-31	DEV Week 4
Post-Oct	**Retrospectives, attendance, challenge quality, maintainer load**

Hacktoberfest 2026 turned an event that once traded a T-shirt for a counted pull request into a month of in-person "Fests," cash-backed open-source AI challenges, and a 24-sticker engagement economy, and it did so by refusing to count pull requests or merge requests toward rewards at all. The stated rationale is maintainer feedback that artificial intelligence made low-effort spam trivial to generate, and the format pivot redirects October toward learning and building with open-weight models rather than the old transaction of contributors showering opted-in repositories with October patches. Major League Hacking now runs the program with DEV and DigitalOcean as presenting partner, participation remains free for anyone aged 13 or older subject to country and event rules, and early public counts show 531 schedulable items across 71 countries, 669,307 open hacktoberfest issues, and a repository ecosystem that still carries roughly 149,000 hacktoberfest-topic repositories even though none of them now earn standing as officially rewardable. Whether the remodel has reduced spam or harmed the contributor pipeline is unverified because the event is still running, but the design decision itself represents the largest rewrite of the program's incentive model since pull requests displaced commit counts in 2015.

October 2026 runs on festivals, five challenges, and stickers

Hacktoberfest 2026 occupies the whole of October 2026 and pairs locally hosted one-day "Fests" with an online program of livestreams, workshops, and five back-to-back DEV challenges, all feeding a common sticker economy instead of a PR ledger. MLH's events API surfaced 488 one-day Fests, 34 MLH member events, and 9 conference pop-ups—531 schedulable items across 71 countries as of mid-October—with India hosting 221 Fests and the United States 66, plus 372 distinct host cities (MLH events API (https://hacktoberfest-api.mlh.com/api/events)). In-person events split into "Hack Days," three-to-twelve-hour mini-hackathons with demonstrations, prizes, minutely checked check-ins, and MLH-backed reimbursement, and meetups, where talks, workshops, and hands-on first-contribution mentoring take the place of competitive builds, with meetups typically swag-only and unfunded (FAQ (https://hacktoberfest.com/questions/); in-person page (https://hacktoberfest.com/in-person/)). Online, DEV ran a Weekend Challenge (Oct 2–5) plus four weekly challenges through Oct 31 under the single prompt "Build something with open-source AI at its core"—running open-weight models, building on open-source agent harnesses or frameworks, or running inference locally—with revealed themes including "Build for a Friend," "Touch Grass," and "Side Hustle," 17 to 18 winners per round, and prize ladders near $2,450 to $2,550 (DEV challenge post (https://dev.to/devteam/hacktoberfest-2026-dev-challenges-five-challenges-one-prompt-a-new-theme-every-week-1e54)). Global Hack Week: Hacktoberfest ran Oct 9–15, 2026 as a free week-long virtual festival of Twitch workshops, Discord mini-events, and tiered challenges (MLH blog (https://blog.mlh.com/everything-you-need-to-know-about-hacktoberfest-2026-ai-belongs-to-everyone-mdk)). All of it resolves into 24 virtual stickers: the first two come from signing in and adding a mailing address, three unlock a mailed sticker pack, ten add a holographic sticker, and fifteen confer Completionist status with a raffle entry for a T-shirt or an Arduino Uno Q board, with packs shipping several weeks after the event (online page (https://hacktoberfest.com/online/)). Winning builds visibly clustered around hyper-local, on-device, open-weight AI—field-card generation, safety alerts, air-quality readers—and "side-hustle" micro-tools for invoices and listings, with winners emphasizing on-device inference, privacy, and durable, observable agent sessions (DEV winner announce (https://dev.to/devteam/congrats-to-the-hacktoberfest-open-source-ai-challenge-touch-grass-winners-152c)).

Maintainer burden and AI spam ended pull-request accounting

Pull-request bookkeeping ended because a decade of fixes never closed the loop between an

externally supplied incentive and the fixed cost of maintainer review. The original 2014 model rewarded 50 commits with a T-shirt and 2015 replaced commits with four accepted pull or merge requests; by 2020 organizers counted 621,000 October pull requests, of which 9,598 were flagged spam or invalid and 172,599 landed in repositories that had never opted in, a surge one maintainer, Domenic Denicola, described as a corporate-sponsored distributed denial of service attack against the open-source maintainer community, while another, Drew DeVault, framed the month as "spamtoberfest" (The Register 2020 (https://www.theregister.com/software/2020/10/01/open-source-devs-drown-in-digitaloceans-latest-tsunami-of-pull-request-spam-that-is-hacktoberfest/832083); Domenic Denicola (https://domenic.me/hacktoberfest/)). DigitalOcean's mid-event response on October 3, 2020 added repository opt-in through the hacktoberfest topic, a hacktoberfest-accepted acceptance path, spam and invalid labels, bans for repeat offenders, and a seven-day review window, and later an advisory council, but behavior adapted rather than stopped—the same ecosystem still saw 39,859 pull requests in 2023, 14.91% of tracked traffic, flow to repositories created to be contributed to (Developer Relations case study (https://developerrelations.com/case-studies/overcoming-hacktoberfest-spam/)). Organizers rebranded the problem continuously: shirts came off in 2023, the completion bar rose from four to six pull requests in 2025 with a 10,000-shirt cap, yet a commonly cited OpenSSF-attributed estimate still put roughly 35% of Hacktoberfest-labeled pull requests closed without merging in 2024, and a maintainer-led analysis of Linux Foundation-style projects second-sourced the figure through a DEV community post rather than an OpenSSF portal (DEV post (https://dev.to/tamizuddin/beyond-pr-counts-how-hacktoberfest-2026s-quality-first-pivot-is-reshaping-open-source-development-cii)). Generative AI then broke the cost side: a 2025 analysis of repositories with more than five thousand stars found pull-request volume 6.80% above counterfactual, one-time contributors opening 5.84% more pull requests while their merge rate fell 18.18%, and roughly 520 excess pull requests a week, because the friction that once separated curiosity from submission fell away while the one person reviewers' time never scaled (arXiv 2607.04003 (https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.04003)). Documented AI side effects in adjacent maintainer communities included fabricated repository screenshots, unreviewable diffs, and security report validity collapsing toward one in twenty or thirty at cURL, which ended its six-year bug bounty in January 2026 (arXiv 2607.04003 (https://arxiv.org/abs/2607.04003)). Hacktoberfest's 2026 mission page collapses all of this into one argument that artificial intelligence makes low-quality pull requests easier than ever, so the program stops incentivizing pull requests and redirects toward education, open-weight models, and local events (mission (https://hacktoberfest.com/mission/)).

Contribution pathways shifted from quotas to claimed issues and judged builds

The new model disperses contribution effort rather than concentrating it behind a quota, because projects can still invite October contributors without shipping account to the program. About 148,820 public repositories carry the hacktoberfest topic and 25,097 carry hacktoberfest-accepted, but those conventions no longer gate rewards and function mostly as discovery signals (GitHub topics (https://github.com/topics/hacktoberfest)). A public aggregator indexed about 669,307 open hacktoberfest issues in mid-October 2026, roughly 517,632 effectively unclaimed, at an average annotated difficulty of 3.7 out of 5 with 11% estimated to take a day or less, with claims increasingly managed through comment-first claim rules rather than first-to-open pull requests (Good First Issue (https://www.goodfirstissue.org/labels/hacktoberfest)). Maintainer recommendation across 2026 reads like a quality recipe rather than a checklist: claim before work, linked issues with Fixes #123, developer-certificate-of-origin signing with git commit -s, focused diffs, documentation and

tests for behavior change, CI confirmation, and disclosure of meaningful artificial intelligence use (Boomspot workflow (https://www.boomspot.com/how-to-find-good-first-issues-for-hacktoberfest-2026); Scrimba guide (https://scrimbaguide.tech/blog/hacktoberfest-2026-first-pull-request/)). The representative beginner deliverables are correspondingly modest: documentation additions, unit tests, internationalization, checksum and software-bill-of-materials documentation, typo and link fixes, and small refactors, many of them avoiding build or runtime pathways outright (TunaOS challenge page (https://tunaos.org/docs/tunaos/hacktoberfest-2026)). Against this background the DEV challenges offered a funded route—five rounds plus completion badges and stickers—for participants willing to build a new judged project from scratch, with writing quality the most heavily weighted criterion on top of relevance, creativity, technical execution, and meaningful partner-technology use (DEV challenge post (https://dev.to/devteam/hacktoberfest-2026-dev-challenges-five-challenges-one-prompt-a-new-theme-every-week-1e54)). The result is more expressive but less navigable than the old quota: discovery now chains the Fest finder, issue aggregators, DEV's challenge hub, and community guides, and a documented first-time participant publicly mistook the new rules for PR counting in October, while others worried that the highest-prize DEV tracks accept only participants 18 or older even though general Hacktoberfest welcomes participants 13 or older (FAQ (https://hacktoberfest.com/questions/); Reddit thread (https://www.reddit.com/r/hacktoberfest/comments/1vmd0bn/what_is_it_with_hacktoberfest_this_time/)).

Maintainers, sponsors, and accessibility split along geography and format

Maintainers gained a veto over October's administrative load and lost a predictable October traffic spike at the same time. With no official reward for pull requests, a maintainer can treat the hacktoberfest topic as recruitment rather than accounting, and teams such as the .NET nanoFramework reported running "contributor month" anyway, combining curated issues, first replies under 48 hours, Discord support, and explicit welcome for artificial-intelligence-assisted code that a human can read and test (.NET nanoFramework post (https://dev.to/josesimoes/hacktoberfest-stopped-counting-prs-were-running-a-contributor-month-anyway-c-on-microcontrollers-m8)). The countervailing risk is structural skew: open-weight and agent challenges channel cash and partner credits toward projects that adopt featured tools, while routine maintenance and non-artificial-intelligence infrastructure absorb none of that attention, and at least one prominent commenter on the MLH announcement post warned that the new format risks flooding repositories with broken AI-generated projects and "dependency hell" (MLH blog comment on DEV (https://blog.mlh.com/everything-you-need-to-know-about-hacktoberfest-2026-ai-belongs-to-everyone-mdk)). Access is host-delegated rather than centrally certified: MLH requires safe and accessible venues, accessible entrances, restrooms, and exits, clear walkways, a code of conduct, and an emergency plan, and it asks hosts to publish logistics, food, and accommodation instructions on the event page, but no Saturday? no documented standards for wheelchair access gradients, interpreters, captions, sensory rooms, or equipment guarantees exist, and accommodations are handled by request against a named host (MLH safety guide (https://hacktoberfest-handbook.mlh.com/fest-planning-guide/safety-and-code-of-conduct)).

Geographic access is sharply uneven: 221 of 488 counted Fests sit in India and 66 in the United States, with many countries holding one event or none—infolowing from late-September 2026 snapshot reporting zero in Bulgaria—and pop-ups attach to ticketed conferences such as AI Engineer and All Things Open, while meetups that welcome participants who "just bring curiosity" remain swag-only and unfunded (MLH API (https://hacktoberfest-api.mlh.com/api/events); WPS snapshot

(https://www.worldprogramming.org/posts/hacktoberfest-2026-changed-the-rules-heres-how-to-actually-join-in-this-october-8afmmr)). Hack Day hosts face a venue, staffing, and equipment burden against a reimbursement floor capped at 50 verified check-ins per event at country-specific rates, with no organizer-provided travel or accommodation support documented (reimbursements handbook (https://hacktoberfest-handbook.mlh.com/reimbursements)). Sponsors did not leave with the PR table; they restructured around it. DigitalOcean and roughly a dozen partners supplied free credits, API tiers, and cash, and the reward layer now runs on category wins of about $100 to $200 per challenge, featured-tool prizes, branded swag bags, completion badges, and 3,000 sponsor envelopes across the field, a structure that funds tool adoption and communication quality rather than upstream patch volume, and one inference from its flat, shallow ladder is that organizers weighted sponsor acquisition and many micro-wins over a single grand-prize incentive (DEV Side Hustle launch post (https://dev.to/devteam/join-the-hacktoberfest-open-source-ai-challenge-side-hustle-2550-in-prizes-across-18-winners-55ba); sponsor page (https://hacktoberfest.com/sponsor/)).

Future programs must measure retention, not registration

The central lesson from 2026 is that reward design dictates contribution behavior long before organizers can observe its damage, and any program that replaces a volume metric with an engagement metric should pre-commit to evaluating the pipeline itself. Hacktoberfest's own history warns against premature verdicts: registration fell from 169,886 in 2020 to 56,768 in 2025, eligible pull requests fell from 483,127 in 2019 to 87,929 in 2025, and at least one analyst, Difegue, argued the collapse tracks the entry-level tech hiring freeze—entry-level openings slid 25% from 2023 to 2024 at the top fifteen firms, software-developer employment among workers aged 22 to 25 sits around 20% below late-2022 peaks, and AI-driven displacement is still contested against a broader market deceleration—as much as incentive design, while others blame the shirt removal, the six-pull-request threshold, and AI-driven portfolio devaluation (tvc-16 analysis (https://tvc-16.science/rip-hacktoberfest.html); Indeed Hiring Lab (https://www.hiringlab.org/2025/07/30/experience-requirements-have-tightened-amid-the-tech-hiring-freeze)). The rigidity-trap risk runs in the other direction too: if programs seal contributors out of real repositories to protect maintainers, the loss is deferred and compounds over years. Program designers should therefore publish a pre-defined evaluation package—attendance and named countries, completion-threshold attainment at three, ten, and fifteen stickers, maintained-quality pull requests and issue contributions from participants in the following quarter, time-to-first-maintainer-response, and returning first-time contributors by January 2027—using data patterns already demonstrated by existing maintainer runbooks and organizational tracking such as Indeed's GitHub-ID pipeline work (tunaOS runbook (https://github.com/tuna-os/tunaOS/blob/main/docs/HACKTOBERFEST-2026.md); Indeed DevRel talk (https://developerrelations.com/talks/how-indeed-more-than-doubled-hacktoberfest-participation-year-over-year)). If 2026 is run that way, it can plausibly keep the pipeline benefits documented in earlier editions—Meilisearch's job offer ten days after a first contribution, freeCodeCamp's monthly quiz growth from 694 to 1,171 questions and 42 to 109 stars in one October, large-provider growth such as ServiceNow's annual review—to a smaller, more sustainable ledger, with verified learning output replacing arbitrary volume as the recognized contribution (Meilisearch blog (https://www.meilisearch.com/blog/hacktoberfest-stories-from-contributor-to-manager); openresource.dev (https://openresource.dev/articles/hacktoberfest)). Without that honesty, the program inherits two incompatible promises and quietly lets the same volunteer maintainer corps absorb the difference.

Conclusion

Hacktoberfest 2026 gives a workable answer to the oldest question in open-source contribution design: whether a program can reward activity without externalizing verification labor, and the available evidence says that counting pull requests could not, because pull requests are cheap to generate, review is not, and generative artificial intelligence blew the gap open. What remains is the harder project of replacing transactional participation with relationships between contributors and projects while still leaving a reliable open path to first contribution and measured value for the volunteers who review work, which means the 2026 format, judged builds, stickers, events, and sponsor credits, will only deserve its name once organizer, sponsor, and project data can show real pipeline health at lower cost than the old quota achieved.

Best practices comparison

Maintainers	Contributors
Run CI gates: tests, no warnings, docs updates	Claim issues explicitly and wait for acknowledgment
Keep PRs roughly under 400 lines	**Respect scope; avoid cosmetic-only sweeps**
Publish CONTRIBUTING.md, templates, difficulty tiers	Write tests and link issues (Fixes #123)
Audit CI/CD and consider OpenSSF Scorecards	**Disclose AI use and own each contribution**
Use accepted labels, opt-in topics, review windows	Use the project before changing it
Define close messages and AI policies	**Submit focused diffs with reproduction details**

Selected sources

- Official FAQ: https://hacktoberfest.com/questions/
- In-person/host pages: https://hacktoberfest.com/in-person/ and https://hacktoberfest.com/host/
- MLH events API: https://hacktoberfest-api.mlh.com/api/events
- DEV challenges: https://dev.to/challenges/hf26
- Global Hack Week: https://ghw.mlh.com/events/open-source
- GitHub topics: https://github.com/topics/hacktoberfest
- GoodFirstIssue: https://www.goodfirstissue.org/labels/hacktoberfest
- Developer Relations spam case study: https://developerrelations.com/case-studies/overcoming-hacktoberfest-spam/
- tvc-16 analysis: https://tvc-16.science/rip-hacktoberfest.html
- Publicasta AI-slop radar: https://publicasta.com/open_source_radar/ai_slop_pull_requests_open_source_maintainers_2026_08_28
- Hacktoberfest Cameroon community: https://hacktoberfest.cm/
- Reddit discussions: https://www.reddit.com/r/hacktoberfest/comments/1vsuffw/hacktoberfest_2026_ai_belongs_to_everyone/